

LAUREL E. WHEELER

University of Alberta
Department of Economics
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Citizenship: United States

ACADEMIC APPOINTMENTS

University of Alberta, Department of Economics Assistant Professor	Edmonton, Alberta July 2019 – present
Center for Indian Country Development, Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis Research Fellow Research Affiliate	Minneapolis, MN Sept 2022 – Dec 2024 Jan 2025 – present

EDUCATION

Duke University PhD in Economics Certificate in College Teaching MA in Economics (non-terminal)	Durham, NC May 2019 2016
University of Oxford, St. Antony's College MSc in Economics for Development	Oxford, England 2011
University of Florida BA in Political Science Minor in Economics; Certificate in International Relations	Gainesville, FL 2007

RESEARCH AREAS

Labor economics, development economics, Indigenous economics

SCHOLARLY WORKS

- LinkedIn(to) Job Opportunities: Experimental Evidence from Job Readiness Training – with Rob Garlick, Eric Johnson, Patrick Shaw, and Marissa Gargano
American Economic Journal: Applied Economics, April 2022
- When the Lender Extends a Helping Hand: Native CDFI Client Counseling and Loan Performance in Indian Country – with Valentina Dimitrova-Grajzl, Peter Grajzl, and Joseph Guse, and Michou Kokodoko
Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy, April 2023
- Beyond Conventional Models: Lending by Native Community Development Financial Institutions – with Valentina Dimitrova-Grajzl, Peter Grajzl, and Joseph Guse, and Michou Kokodoko
Annals of Public and Cooperative Economics, August 2023
- Applying Indigenous Approaches to Economics Instruction – with Larry Chavis
Journal of Economics, Race, and Policy, September 2024
- Harnessing Soft Information to Promote Financial Inclusion: The Case of Native CDFI Business Lending – with Valentina Dimitrova-Grajzl, Peter, Grajzl, Michou Kokodoko, and Lakota Vogel
Journal of Financial Services Research, December 2024
- Fostering Financial Inclusion by Ensuring Cultural Fit: The Case of the NCDFI Industry – with Valentina Dimitrova-Grajzl, Peter, Grajzl, and Michou Kokodoko
American Indian Culture and Research Journal, July 2025

Updated May 2026

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- Mapping the NCDFI Industry: Insights from a New Survey – with Valentina Dimitrova-Grajzl, Peter, Grajzl, and Michou Kokodoko
Community Development, February 2026

Book Chapters:

- Digital Networking and the Case of Youth Unemployment in South Africa – with Patrick Shaw
Springer, “An Introduction to Development Engineering”, 2023
- Outlook on the Economic Impact of COVID-19 on Indigenous Communities and Peoples in Canada – with Areez Gangji and Maggie Jones
Canada: The State of the Federation Series, McGill-Queen’s University Press, December 2025

Working Papers:

- Resource Revenue Sharing Agreements – with Abena Boafoa Darkwah and Lucija Muehlenbachs
Revise & Resubmit at Canadian Public Policy
- Place, Prosperity, and Play: The Local Labor Market Effects of Tribal Gaming – with William B. Grider
Reject & Resubmit at the Journal of Human Resources
- Draining across Borders: How Common Pools Fuel Inequality – with Lucija Muehlenbachs
Under review
- Targeting Economic Relief toward Indigenous Firms and Places: Evidence from Environmental Cleanup – with Lucija Muehlenbachs and Ipek Tastan

Selected Works in Progress:

- Matching Digital Service Export Jobs in Kenya – with Ignacio Rodriguez Hurtado, Caroline Kariuki, Kate Orkin, and Rob Garlick
- The Legacy of Colonial Property Institutions: Economic Costs of a Federal Trusteeship (2019 JMP)

GRANTS

Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council Partnership Engage Grant (\$23,000): 2024
Resources for the Future, Resilient Energy Economies Initiative (\$60,000): 2024
Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council Insight Grant (\$68,000): 2023
International Growth Centre’s Small and Growing Business Evidence Fund (23,000 GBP): 2023
Alberta Gambling Research Institute Major Grant (\$20,000): 2021
Indigenous-Engaged Research Grant (\$5,000): 2021
International Growth Centre’s Small and Growing Business Evidence Fund (73,000 GBP): 2021
Future Energy Systems (\$67,000): 2021
Private Enterprise Development in Low-Income Countries (PEDL) Exploratory Research Grant: 2016

TEACHING

ECON 203 Indigenous Economics, Undergraduate level	Alberta, 2020-present
ECON 403/612 Indigenous Economic Development, Undergraduate/Graduate	Alberta, 2020-2021
ECON 462/603 Urban Economics, Undergraduate/Graduate	Alberta, 2020-2021
ECON 890 Intro to Stata, PhD level	Duke, 2018
Applied Microeconomics, Osher Lifelong Learning Institute	Duke, 2017

PRIOR RESEARCH EXPERIENCE

RTI International	Durham, NC
Independent Contractor – Economics Research Consultant	2015-2019

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Federal Reserve Bank of Minneapolis
CSWEP Fellow in the Center for Indian Country Development

Minneapolis, MN
Summer 2016

Cornell University, Department of Economics
Research Support Specialist – Jim Berry & Damon Clark

Ithaca, New York
2012-2013

Financial Sector Deepening (FSD) Kenya
Research Associate
Oxford Policy Management (OPM)
Economics Consultant

Nairobi, Kenya
2012
Oxford, England
2011

Oxford Centre for the Analysis of Resource-Rich Economies
Research Assistant – Torfinn Harding & Radek Stefanski

Oxford, England
2010-2011

Fieldwork:

- **Kenya** (FSD-Kenya) 2012
- **South Africa** (Duke University and RTI International) 2015, 2016

PROFESSIONAL SERVICES AND AFFILIATIONS

Board of Directors:	Alberta Gambling Research Institute (July 2024 - present)
Editorial board:	Journal of Critical Gambling Studies
Co-investigator:	One Society Network, lead of the Indigenous Communities Sector (2022-2023)
Visiting scholar:	Center for Indian Country Development, Federal Reserve Bank of Mpls (2021)
Referee services:	Economic Journal, Journal of Development Economics, Economics of Education Review, Canadian Public Policy, Ecological Economics, Canadian Journal of Agricultural Economics, Critical Gambling Studies, Telecommunications Policy, Review of Political Economy
Departmental service:	One of founding members of EDI Committee (2021)
Planning committee:	Project on the Economics of Indigenous Peoples and Institutions, now AERIP
Mentoring:	Supervisor with I-STEAM Pathways: Environmental Education Program for Indigenous Students (2021)
Other affiliations:	Association for Economic Research of Indigenous Peoples (AEA); Indigenous Economics Study Group (CEA); American Economic Association; Canadian Economic Association; Alberta Centre for Labour Market Research (Work, Employment, and Labour Markets Signature Area)
Trainings/certificates:	First Nations Information Governance Centre's OCAP training; Protecting Human Research Participants; Annual Census training in records management, data stewardship, and cyber security

CONFERENCE PRESENTATIONS AND INVITED TALKS

Emory University (Atlanta, GA)	2025
Freedom and Justice Conference (Spelman College in Atlanta, GA)	2024
Young Scholars Symposium (Indiana University, by invitation)	2024
Florida State University (Tallahassee, FL)	2023
CICD Native CDFI webinar (virtual)	2023
CTREE Conference (Portland, OR)	2023
Simon Fraser University (Vancouver, BC)	2023
Institute for Public Economics (Edmonton, AB)	2023
Reservation Economic Summit (Las Vegas)	2023
Indigenous Economics Study Group (virtual)	2023
Indian Gaming Tradeshow and Convention (San Diego)	2023
University of Saskatchewan, Role Model Fund Speaker (Saskatoon, SK)	2023

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Southern Economic Association meeting (Ft. Lauderdale)	2022
Empirical Microeconomics Workshop (Banff)	2022
One Society Network seminar series	2022
Economics Society of Northern Alberta	2022
Indigenous Economics Study Group seminar	2022
University of Saskatchewan (Saskatoon, SK)	2022
Future Energy Systems webinar on the Ethics and Politics of Energy Systems	2022
Center for Indian Country Development	2022
Harvard Project on American Indian Economic Development, Land Back Convening	2022
CEA panel, Indigenous Economics Study Group	2021
Centre for the Study of African Economies (Oxford, UK)	2021
CEA panel, Indigenous Economics Study Group (Toronto) – canceled due to COVID	2020
Centre for the Study of African Economies (Oxford, UK) – canceled due to COVID	2020
University of Calgary (Calgary, AB)	2019
Montana State University (Bozeman)	2019
University of Alberta (Edmonton)	2019
Rollins College (Winter Park, FL)	2019
Luxembourg Institute of Socio-Economic Research (Luxembourg)	2019
Sacramento State University (CA)	2019
Colby College (Waterville, ME)	2019
NBER Project on Economics of Indigenous Peoples & Institutions (Cambridge)	2018
Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management Conference (DC)	2018
Midwest Economics Association Conference (Ohio)	2017
Census Bureau's Center for Economic Studies Seminar Series (DC)	2017
International Population Conference (Cape Town, South Africa)	2017
Virginia Military Institute/Washington and Lee Seminar Series (Virginia)	2017

FELLOWSHIPS, AWARDS, AND HONORS

Faculty of Arts Excellence in Indigenization, Access, Community, Belonging, & Decolonization (I and ACB & D)	
Initiatives in Teaching Award. (<i>University of Alberta</i>)	2026
Preparing Future Faculty Fellow (<i>1 of 24 Duke graduate fellows</i>)	2018-2019
Kenan Institute for Ethics Graduate Fellowship (<i>1 of 15 Duke graduate fellows</i>)	2017-2018
Price Theory Summer Camp at the University of Chicago (<i>1 of appx 20, various universities</i>)	2017
CSWEP Fellowship, American Economic Association (<i>AEA</i>)	2016

POPULAR PRESS AND MEDIA COVERAGE

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- Print interview in CBC News on April 27, 2026: "First Nations chief worries legalized online gambling will hurt critical band revenues"
 - Center for Indian Country Development web article in May 2025: "Using tailored services, Native CDFIs work to foster financial resilience"
 - Center for Indian Country Development web article in May 2024: "Native CDFIs connect Indian Country to credit and capital"
 - Center for Indian Country Development web article in February 2024: "Native entrepreneurs face credit-access challenges"
 - Print coverage in Tribal Business News on August 31, 2023: "Unpacking the wisdom of Native CDFIs"
 - Print interview in Buffalo's Fire on July 19, 2023: "Good news for Indian Country: Business lenders find Native borrowers safe bet"
 - Print interview in Tribal Business News on March 12, 2023: "REPORT: Character may be more important than credit scores when it comes to Native CDFI business lending"
 - Print interview in the Capital Journal on February 17, 2023: "Financial access could bring benefits on Pine Ridge Reservation"

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- Center for Indian Country Development web article in February 2023: “Native CDFIs bring holistic approach to assessing credit risk”
- Wheeler, L. (2022). Does Tribal Gaming Generate Net Benefits? *Critical Gambling Studies*. <https://doi.org/10.29173/cgs142>
- Wheeler, L. (2021). The ‘New Buffalo’ Confronts a Pandemic: Implications of the COVID-19 Shock for the Indigenous Gaming Industry. *Critical Gambling Studies*. <https://doi.org/10.29173/cgs93>
- Radio interview on CBC Edmonton’s Radio Active show on April 22, 2021
Requoted in multiple news sources, including *Canadian Gaming Business*, *Casino Reports*, and *Yahoo News*